

The First Impasse in Prayer

Choosing Jesus Requires the Holy Spirit to Reveal the Counsel of God

Again, we are going to pass in review. When we begin tonight, it will be with John 16:12.

We have been studying Luke 14 for the last three or four services because that chapter contains the instructions for humbling yourself, which causes the exaltation that can come from God and God alone.

These last services have been intensely interesting to me because the subject of that entire chapter is this:

He that exalteth himself shall be abased; and he that humbleth himself shall be exalted.

I would be lying to you if I told you I did not want to experience the exaltation that comes from my Father.

In the process of studying that chapter, we found out how a man humbles himself. We found it in Luke 14:26:

If any man come to me, and hate not his father, and mother, and wife, and children, and brethren, and sisters, yea, and his own life also, he cannot be my disciple.

And whosoever doth not bear his cross, and come after me, cannot be my disciple.

Then He says:

For which of you, intending to build a tower, sitteth not down first, and counteth the cost, whether he have sufficient to finish it?

Lest haply, after he hath laid the foundation, and is not able to finish it, all that behold it begin to mock him,

Saying, This man began to build, and was not able to finish.

That whole chapter goes on to show how to humble yourself and receive the exaltation that comes from God.

The way a man humbles himself is to choose Jesus. By choosing Jesus, he counts the cost. That ensures he will have enough to finish his tower, which is his life, his call, and what God has separated him to do. It means walking out of every damnable thing Jesus set him free from, and walking into everything Jesus said he is.

When a man chooses Jesus, he has counted the cost. To choose Jesus is to humble yourself and make sure you have enough to finish your tower.

But if there was ever a confused group of people, I think it is religious people.

Look around and see thousands and thousands of churches in this city alone that name the name of Jesus. Look under church listings in the so-called Christian faith, and look at the variations. Yet many of those factions can hardly sit next to each other and worship in the same service. The reason is that their variances are enough that they have separated themselves and become separate entities.

It is incredible. All these variations are a monument to the seductive power of Satan and the deception of the carnal mind.

When we see something like this, we begin to wonder. Jesus said the Holy Ghost has come to guide us into all truth, and His Word is truth. He said to meditate the Word day and night.

When we see all these denominations, with only one Word, only one Holy Ghost, and one commission to guide us into all truth, we begin to think, "How does the Holy Spirit get involved in a man? How does He get involved in us so He can take the counsel that left the heart of God in the form of the Word--the Word you are holding in your lap--and reconstruct it in your life so it becomes the counsel, light, and understanding we need to walk by?"

Psalm 1 says:

Blessed is the man that walketh not in the counsel of the ungodly, nor standeth in the way of sinners, nor sitteth in the seat of the scornful.

But his delight is in the law of the Lord; and in his law doth he meditate day and night.

The reason I am a blessed man of God is that I do not have to take my counsel from the world.

In view of thousands upon thousands of man-made doctrines, and only one Holy Spirit, there still has to be a way He gets involved with my spirit to take that counsel and give me the understanding of it, so I do not have to take my counsel from the world.

I am here to tell you there is.

For four days I have preached on choosing Jesus. The true way a man humbles himself is to choose Jesus. Jesus said that if any man comes to Him and does not hate--does not violently, vehemently, emphatically choose Him over everything that exists--he cannot be His disciple.

He listed father, mother, brother, sister, wife, and children. He is not telling you that by choosing Him you will lose them. He goes on in the chapter to guarantee that by choosing Him you will have enough building materials to finish your tower and win them, not lose them.

You lose them through compromise, not through choosing Him.

He had to find a strong word. Outside of Jesus, you could do everything for your family that could possibly be done. You could make them rich, make them world conquerors, make them the elite of the living. All you could do for your family in the natural would end up looking like hate when you find out what you gave up in glory.

In view of all this religiosity, and a man preaching, "Choose Jesus, choose Jesus, choose Jesus," while all these religions run around saying, "This is the way we believe over here," and, "We will not fellowship with them because we believe it this way," and, "That is all right, because we will not fellowship with either of you," the sheep are the ones who suffer.

You are supposed to choose Jesus. The elders have been charged to feed the flock of God. Who suffers? Many times you have been victims of ambitious men.

Jesus said to choose Him and you will receive exaltation. But if men destroy the Word, you do not know how to make the choice. Many times you are the victims. You do not know which way to go. You do not know if truth is sideways, up, frontwards, or backwards.

You want to humble yourself. You want the exaltation that comes from God and God alone, but you do not know how to choose Jesus.

This is where the Holy Ghost comes in.

The Logos Created All Things, and the Spirit Regenerates and Reveals Him

John 1:1 says:

| In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God.

The Greek word is Logos. In the beginning was the Logos, and the Logos was God, and the Logos stood face to face, coequal with God in all ways. All things were made by the Logos, and without the Logos was not anything made that was made--no, not one single thing.

In the role of redemption, the Logos created everything that exists. Before anything that exists had a beginning, the Logos existed, and He created everything that exists.

You and I now know Him as the glorified Man, Jesus.

His role in redemption was creation. The Holy Spirit's role in redemption is regeneration. After Jesus paid the price on the cross, the Holy Spirit was sent to regenerate us, to represent the cross, and to reveal Jesus Christ inside us.

If you are going to choose Jesus, then just as violently and vehemently you are going to have to choose the work of the Holy Spirit in your personal life. You cannot choose Jesus without choosing to allow the Holy Spirit to work in you.

We are about to give you a key that, if you use it, will cause Jesus to be revealed.

John 16:12 says:

I have yet many things to say unto you, but ye cannot bear them now.

Howbeit when he, the Spirit of truth, is come, he will guide you into all truth: for he shall not speak of himself; but whatsoever he shall hear, that shall he speak: and he will shew you things to come.

He shall glorify me: for he shall receive of mine, and shall shew it unto you.

I like that name: the Spirit of truth. I feel very secure in that name.

To choose Jesus is to choose the Holy Spirit, because the Holy Spirit is the revealer of Jesus.

He will not speak of Himself. Whatever He hears, that He will speak. He will show you things to come. He will glorify Jesus, receive of Jesus, and show it to you.

In the beginning, before anything had a beginning, Jesus was known as the Logos, the Word of God, and He created everything that exists.

When we get into Hebrews and talk about faith, Scripture says:

Through faith we understand that the worlds were framed by the word of God.

We were not there on the edge of eternity, so we understand by faith. We were not there, so we look back by faith and understand that the worlds were framed by the Word of God.

Sometimes we visualize God standing on the edge of eternity, choosing some special faith-filled words, and saying, "World, fill yourself out there in the universe," filling His words with faith and throwing them out until the world suddenly hangs in the void.

That is not what it says. It says that by faith we understand the worlds were framed by the Logos of God. In the beginning was the Logos, the Logos was with God, and the Logos stood face to face, coequal with God. All things were made by Him, and without Him was not anything made that was made, no, not one single thing.

In the role of redemption, God the Father, Jehovah, took the role of Planner. The Logos took the role of Creator. The Holy Spirit took the role of Regenerator.

Even between Genesis 1:1 and Genesis 1:2, when it says:

In the beginning God created the heaven and the earth.

That was however many millions of years ago when He created this universe. But in the second verse, when the Spirit moved upon the face of the waters, He was moving upon something that already existed. The Holy Spirit gave the earth a facelift. He performed regeneration, just as He is doing regeneration inside your heart.

To choose Jesus is to choose the Holy Spirit, because He has come to guide me into all truth and to reveal Jesus.

Tongues for Personal Edification Is a Key to the Revealing of Jesus

I want to look at a key to the revealing of Jesus, because God knows I am hungry. I choose Jesus. I humble myself and choose Jesus by an act of my own will.

When the Holy Spirit steps in, He begins to reveal Him whom I have chosen.

If I were to give you a key and guarantee that this key would play a most important role in the revealing of Jesus, would you use it?

Go to 1 Corinthians 14.

How long am I going to hang around this? Until it gets into your spirit, my friend. How long am I going to hang around it? Until you hate failure.

1 Corinthians 14:1 says:

Follow after charity, and desire spiritual gifts, but rather that ye may prophesy.
For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.
But he that prophesieth speaketh unto men to edification, and exhortation, and comfort.
He that speaketh in an unknown tongue edifieth himself; but he that prophesieth edifieth the church.

How many of you have ever prophesied? Raise those little hands higher. Do not be afraid.

He that prophesies speaks to men to edification, exhortation, and comfort. He that speaks in an unknown tongue edifies himself. He that prophesies edifies the church.

Paul says:

I would that ye all spake with tongues, but rather that ye prophesied: for greater is he that prophesieth than he that speaketh with tongues, except he interpret, that the church may receive edifying.

There is an exception to the rule: except he interpret, that the church may receive edifying.

Then Paul says:

Now, brethren, if I come unto you speaking with tongues, what shall I profit you, except I shall speak to you either by revelation, or by knowledge, or by prophesying, or by doctrine?

This starts to get very interesting. Some of you have guessed by now that, once again, in the revealing of Jesus Christ in your life, a major key is this tongue for personal edification.

If I choose Jesus to humble myself so He may exalt me, then the Holy Spirit is the revealer of Jesus. To choose Jesus, I must also choose what the Holy Spirit has said.

Prophecy Edifies the Church; Tongues Edifies the Individual

Let us talk about tongues for personal edification again, because we are working toward something.

If I prophesy, will the church receive edification, exhortation, and comfort? Yes. Why? Because the Word of God says they will.

Let me make it interesting for you. If I were to prophesy or interpret a tongue, and you knew it was God, and I stood up and said, "Yea, I would say unto thee"--it would have to be King James or some of you would not believe it was really Him--and if it were a real word of God, and I said, "Everyone who will raise their hands and worship Me for five minutes shall undoubtedly, by ten o'clock tomorrow morning, receive one thousand dollars apiece," your hands would go up so fast they would break the sound barrier.

Five minutes. Your arms might get tired, but you would keep them up there. If it were the true Word of God, we could all skip church in the morning and give our testimonies at eleven o'clock.

"How did yours come in?"

"I was walking down the street, and a man jumped out. I thought he was going to hold me up, but he gave me a thousand-dollar bill."

"How did yours come in?"

"The most unusual thing. A policeman pulled me over, red lights and everything, and when I got out, he handed me a thousand dollars."

Do you not think God can do that? He could send a bird right into your house with a thousand-dollar bill clutched in its little fist. It would look at you and say, "Hold your hand out," and put it in your hand. Getting it to you is no problem.

If it were the true Word of God and He wanted to do something like that, you would be edified, exhorted, and comforted. We would all be sitting in the service enjoying the presence of God, and suddenly, collectively, God's mind would be made known to the church. We would be edified, exhorted, and comforted.

But the next verse says that he who prophesies edifies the church, while he who speaks in tongues edifies himself.

Paul was not talking about just edification. He was talking about edification, exhortation, and comfort.

Verse 3 says:

He that prophesieth speaketh unto men to edification, and exhortation, and comfort.

Why? Because collectively the whole church knows the mind of God. Verse 4 says:

He that speaketh in an unknown tongue edifieth himself; but he that prophesieth edifieth the church.

He that speaks in an unknown tongue is not edifying the church. He is edifying himself as an individual. But he is not only edifying himself; he is exhorting and comforting himself.

Why? For the same reason that prophecy edifies the church. When I prophesy, the mind of God is made manifest to all of you. When I pray in tongues, I am edified because the mind of God is revealed to me individually.

You can pray in tongues as much as you want, as long as you want. You are having church inside your spirit.

"Where are you going to church?"

"It does not look like it to me."

It is not a building I reported to. It is a closet. Even if I am standing in a crowd, I can go into my closet, the secret place of the Most High, and comfort, exhort, and edify myself. We are having church inside my spirit. I am being exhorted and comforted for the same reason the church is: the mind of God is being revealed.

That makes me want to pray in tongues. I could stop right now and tell you, "Have your church. I am going to go have mine."

Mysteries Spoken in the Spirit Are Divine Counsel Outside Satan's Jurisdiction

Now we begin to understand verse 2 more thoroughly:

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

No man understands him because this is not meant to be interpreted by other men. This is a language of communication between me and my Father God. Nobody else understands it. It is not the tongue to be interpreted; it is the tongue to be edified with.

No man understands him, but in the Spirit he is speaking mysteries.

Any time I stand back and exhort, comfort, and edify myself--any time I start having church in my spirit--Paul says I am speaking mysteries and divine secrets.

No man understands me because it is not meant to be interpreted. I have checked into the Holy of Holies. This interaction is between me and my Father God, and it is nobody else's business. He and I are having church. The Holy Spirit prays through me, and God answers back. That is where the exhortation, comfort, and edification come from.

One day I said, "Father, no man understands me?"

He said, "No."

I said, "Does that mean the devil does not either?"

Would it not be something if you were praying in tongues and you did not understand what you were saying, because verse 14 says your spirit prays but your understanding is unfruitful, yet the devil understood it? Would God leave me out and let him in?

No man understands him, but in the Spirit he speaks mysteries to God.

Under the Old Testament, they had the Holy of Holies, which was a type and shadow of this day when God would be my God and my body would be His temple. He would dwell in me.

In the shadow, there was the Holy of Holies, the inner court, and the outer court. Nobody but the high priest was allowed into the Holy of Holies with the sacrifice of the people. The priests ministered in the inner court, and the people ministered in the outer court.

But in this tabernacle where God dwells, the Holy of Holies is my born-again, new-creation human spirit. Just as the Holy of Holies in the tabernacle was out of Satan's jurisdiction, my Holy of Holies, my born-again new-creation spirit, is out of Satan's jurisdiction.

If Satan had had the audacity to walk into the Holy of Holies, God would have taken his head off right about the shoulders. It was out of his jurisdiction. He was not allowed in there.

Satan is not allowed in my Holy of Holies. Only One is allowed there: Jesus Christ, represented by the Holy Ghost.

Every time I go to church in my spirit and start speaking with tongues, it is out of Satan's jurisdiction. The whole thing takes place in my Holy of Holies. My human spirit is in divine communication with God Himself. It is none of the devil's business.

Can you imagine how frustrated he gets when you go to church and edify, exhort, and comfort yourself for a month, eight hours a day? He gets a distressed, perplexed look on his face because the whole transaction is taking place in the Holy of Holies, out of his jurisdiction. All he can do is run around the perimeter. The inner court is the soul realm. The outer court is the flesh. About as close as he can get is a little imagination in the soul realm.

But what transpires in the Holy of Holies is none of his business.

The Holy Spirit is revealing Jesus there. He is creating this supernatural language. It is coming into existence in the Holy of Holies, and it has linked me into divine communication with God Himself.

Imagine the devil biting his fingernails up to the knuckles, wondering what is going on. He will have to wait. You have been edifying yourself for three months, seven hours a day, communicating divine secrets and mysteries. Suddenly God says, "It is time to answer that prayer," and the whole transaction took place inside where the devil could not get to it.

"What is going on? What is going on?"

"You will be able to see soon enough, devil. It will start manifesting around him. Besides, it is none of your business."

It is called edification.

Praying in the Holy Ghost Builds Us Above a Sense-Dominated Walk

Go to Jude 19-21:

These be they who separate themselves, sensual, having not the Spirit.

But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost, Keep yourselves in the love of God, looking for the mercy of our Lord Jesus Christ unto eternal life.

These are sensual, sense-ruled, having not the Spirit. But because you have the Spirit, you do not have to be sense-ruled.

Beloved, you can build yourselves up on your most holy faith by praying in the Holy Ghost and keeping yourselves in the love of God.

As faith people, we should appreciate verse 19, because if there is anything we have wanted to attain to, it is a walk of faith where we are not moved by what we see, hear, or feel. Those are the senses. We are only moved by what we believe, and we choose Jesus and His Word as the final say-so in our lives.

If faith people had a creed, it would be this:

I am not moved by what I see, hear, or feel. I am only moved by what I believe, and I take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life.

Then we should appreciate a verse like this. Jude says they are sensual, sense-dominated, more moved by what they see, hear, or feel. They are dominated by the devil through the flesh.

But you, beloved, do not have to be that way, because you have the Holy Ghost. You can build yourselves up above that mess on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost and keeping yourselves in the love of God.

When I pray in tongues, I am speaking mysteries and divine secrets. The reason I am edified from praying in tongues is not that I receive some kind of charge according to the laws of physics. The reason I am edified is the same reason the church is edified by prophecy: the mind of God is made manifest.

Collectively, the church understands God's mind for that service. But he who prays in an unknown tongue edifies himself. The reasons are the same. He is coming to understand the mind of God individually in his own life.

When I speak with tongues, the reason I receive a charge is not biological. It is not that someone turns on a switch and suddenly my eyes go full charge. I am being edified because I am being exhorted and comforted by God. In a form of prayer, I am communicating divine secrets and mysteries before Him.

When that transaction is complete and He answers those mysteries, they come back to me as exhortation and comfort, building me up in God. They edify me above a walk in which I am more moved by my senses--what I see, hear, and feel--than by what the Word of God says about my problem.

I am communicating divine secrets and mysteries, the same mysteries hidden in God since before the foundation of the world. In a nutshell, they are the same mysteries Paul was made a minister of: Christ in you, to you, and through you, the hope of glory.

Every time I exhort myself, comfort myself, retreat into the Holy of Holies, close the door with my High Priest, and pray with tongues, I am speaking the same mysteries hidden in God since before the foundation of the world. A transaction begins to take place where I extract from God the understanding of those divine secrets and mysteries. My spirit is exhorted, edified, and comforted with the understanding of Christ in me, to me, and through me, the hope of glory.

No devil in hell can bind you in the sense realm when you are edifying yourself above it and keeping yourself in the love of God.

The Sheep Suffer When Seduced Teachers Replace the Inner Anointing

I am excited, because the sheep tend to be such victims. One of the most powerful works of the flesh is our capacity for deception.

Look around at all the different churches and variations proclaiming Christianity. It is a monument to the fact that one of the most powerful works of the flesh is our capacity for deception.

If you do not believe it, look at the works of the flesh. Heresy is listed there. Heresy is wrong understanding of biblical doctrine. It is a work of the flesh.

Listen closely. This will save you much heartache in the future.

Jim Jones led nine hundred computer programmers, janitors, school teachers, factory workers, and businessmen to their deaths in a foreign country called Guyana. These people were sane, sensible, everyday people like you. But they fell to one of our most destructive capacities: the capacity for seduction.

Heresy is a work of the flesh.

That is why John says:

Ye need not that any man teach you: but as the same anointing teacheth you of all things, and is truth, and is no lie.

He is not talking about doing away with teachers. That would contradict the Word of God. He is talking about those who seduce you through teaching.

Concerning those who seduce you, how can you ask the teacher who is seducing you, "What is truth and what is not?" He will teach you error. That is why you must lean on the anointing inside you that cannot lie, that has been sent to guide you into all truth. His Word is truth. This anointing is truth and cannot lie. He will teach you all things concerning seduction, what is truth, and what is not.

Because of our capacity for seduction, and because doctrine pulls us in ten thousand directions, the devil does not have to come and whip you as individuals. All he has to do is sell your teachers a bill of goods that is not truth. Pretty soon you have doctrines against speaking with tongues, doctrines against the infilling of the Holy Ghost, and for those who are spiritually deficient, even doctrines against the born-again experience. Then they have elite fellowship clubs.

Let the devil begin his seduction, and powerful moves of God end up in religious formats that exclude even the born-again experience.

He does not have to whip you as individuals. All he has to do is whip the leadership, and you open your mouth and believe anything they say.

Not if we can get you praying in tongues.

Some of you have been around long enough to have had your wool pulled this way and that way. You have been sheared a few times. We have been pulled here and pulled there. We are preached our responsibility to the kingdom, but foremost and first, the responsibility of the elders among you is our charge to feed the flock of God.

We are supposed to take our staff and go out and kill the lion and the bear. We are supposed to lay our lives on the altar for you.

I do not think you realize how precious you are in His sight. You are a treasure He gave His life for, and He is going to spend eternity with you. He loves you. Any time we preachers get in trouble, it is when we start misusing the sheep. Then we are on the bottom of God's list.

When did Jesus turn on them and say, "You bunch of hypocrites. On the outside you appear as white sepulchres, but inside you are full of decaying dead men's bones"? He said, "God knows your heart. You devour widows' houses, take everything they have, and then make long prayers of pretense to cover it up." He said they were an abomination in the sight of God.

If you want to make Jesus angry, if you want Him to call you a viper, a hypocrite, and a snake, misuse one of His little ones--especially those who have given themselves on the altar to pray, intercede, and fill heaven with people.

The First Impasse Reveals the Ceiling That Has Limited Your Life

Many of you are being pulled in many directions. Many have come to the realization that five years ago you were sitting in a chair much like the one you are sitting in now, but your life shows no more victory now than it did then. One day looks like the next. Two, five, or ten years go by, and the same little things that whipped you then are whipping you now.

It does not take a lightning-quick mind to realize that there is some kind of ceiling on your life you have not been able to penetrate. The things you do for God do not get any greater because they are contained within that ceiling.

That is why we do not know how to sell our lives out to the One who reveals Jesus. That is called a walk in the Spirit.

I have been troubled, not as though I have no peace. I have never had as much peace. But I have been troubled with a raging godly jealousy for His sheep.

I hurt when I see so much for you, and you are walking in so little. You are so dangerous to the devil, but you are being whipped by him.

Some of you have come to the realization that your life is not showing much more fruit than it did last year or the year before. Your knowledge has increased, but not your ability to use it. There is some kind of ceiling.

Let me tell you what happens when you whip the first impasse in prayer, and I will tell you what that first one is.

The first wall you will run up against in prayer is the wall that will do everything it can to get you back out of prayer.

The first impasse, the first wall you will encounter in praying in tongues for edification, is the impasse that stubbornly resists you to get you back out of prayer.

Once you get on the other side of that wall, you are heading for unexplored territory.

For higher and higher in Me shall a man soar like an eagle that is free. Rejoice and be glad, for My power I have placed within you, and it can be had. I will edify you. I will exhort you. I will comfort you. When I am through, you will have come through, and you will see what I have prepared for you, and you will be exceedingly glad.

Let us say, for the sake of teaching, that the ceiling is that impasse. You have been operating beneath it. Sometimes you are up against it, rubbing right against it, but you have never operated above it because it is an impasse.

Jude said you do not have to be sensual or sense-ruled like those who do not have the Holy Spirit. You can build yourselves up above a sense-dominated walk by praying in the Holy Ghost and keeping yourself in the love of God.

Legalism Tries to Turn a Prayer Commitment Into Condemnation

Let me tell you what will begin to happen.

When we first begin praying, we are often militant. What the devil wants to do in the first stages of your defeat is get you into legalism.

Legalism looks like this: you make a quality decision, "I am going to pray two hours a day, or three, without fail." You feel good about yourself. "I have made the decision. I feel good about myself."

So you report faithfully to the closet for about a month. Then suddenly you miss two or three sessions. Because the devil plants legalism, he says, "Look at that. You missed three sessions. You think God can use you today?"

How many have had that happen? How many have committed to prayer legalistically and fallen out of it?

The first thing he says is, "Look at that. You committed, you rascal. You made a vow and broke it."

Would to God that falling out of prayer were your worst fault.

Because we are in legalism, we feel condemned if we do not fill the cubicle space for the two hours. We treat it like a duty, and then we feel condemned about it.

Let me give you some reality. God is not keeping track the way we said He is. He is not keeping track of the hours you put in last month. The part of you He fellowships with is the part of your life that has received change from the praying.

So what if you miss three days? The biggest trick of the devil is to get you to quit.

The part of you God fellowships with is the part that has received the new change. He has a new place to fellowship within you now. When you get past the first attacks of legalism, say, "I missed a week, but by golly, I am going back. I am going to keep going back and keep going back."

What you are building yourself toward is the revealing of the things inside you that are the character flaws that keep knocking you out of prayer before you get past the first impasse, which is consistency in prayer.

The only reason you fall out of prayer is that there is some fault in your character that will not let you continue in prayer.

As you pray and edify and edify and edify, the first thing God does is build you up to the bottom of the ceiling where the faults lie. Then, when you are strong enough inside, He shines light on those faults so that at the strongest point of your edification, you can deal with them.

This is how most of us deal with them: we quit.

Emotional Resistance Means the Spirit Has Brought You to the Wall

Let us talk about the faults that stop us. I would say most of them lie in the area of the unknown.

How many of you have been in revivals where the power of God moved in such a way that a semi truck and trailer were needed to carry away the discarded wheelchairs and crutches after the meeting?

I know of one man who came to Los Angeles. The meeting grew in such power and velocity that one night fifty blind people had gathered. They brought them up on the platform or stood them around the front. This man stood up and said, "I am going to pray the prayer of faith in the name of Jesus. Then to release your faith, I am going to snap my fingers."

When he snapped his fingers, forty-nine of the fifty blind eyes instantly opened.

How many of you have ever been in a revival like that in America?

The reason we hit such an emotional impasse is because the devil hammers us continually:

"What makes you think anything is really going to happen? You are sacrificing yourself with all these hours. You could be doing something much more productive. You are forsaking your family."

Because almost everyone in here has never seen anything like that, you do not even know what you are contending for. The walk is a walk of absolute faith.

When I tell you those things are on the other side of two major impasses, I am telling you the only reason God is not moving in that kind of revival now is that if He suddenly moved you into standing in the gap between that kind of revival and the devil's determination not to let it happen, the devil would turn on you to make sure you did not let it happen. In the state you are in, he would destroy you because you are so full of fear, worry, and character flaws that will not even keep you in a closet an hour a week.

I am not trying to be mean. I am telling you we are learning intercession to contend for revival.

You will build yourself up, and those faults will begin to be revealed. Let me show you how they come.

Intercessory groups pray themselves to a certain place, and then they often get reputations for becoming flaky intercessors. How many have ever been in a flaky intercessory meeting?

Most of these groups start out great. They say, "We are going to pray revival down on our city. We are going to pray for the pastor. We are intercessors."

They get in and start praying. They go into groanings and think they are intercessory groanings, but they are not. They are still locked in personal edification, getting themselves out from under a sense-dominated realm, building themselves up and keeping themselves in the love of God.

They think they are making intercession. They are not.

The difference between personal edification and intercession is that intercession works. If you stand in the gap, something will happen. The back starts filling up with sinners, and the next thing you know they are running to the front. You broke the devil's hold off them. You stood in the gap.

If you are interceding for five, six, seven, eight, nine, or ten years and do not see anything take place, you are not in it. You had better learn about the impasse, because until you get past it, you will be in personal edification. You cannot take the heat on the other side unless you are walking in more peace.

You pray yourself up to that impasse, and all of a sudden the Holy Spirit says, "I have edified them. I have exhorted them. I have comforted them. I have revealed things from the Word. I have built them up. They are stronger than they have ever been. It is time to reveal one of those character flaws."

Suddenly gross emotional feelings rise. They become so strong you cannot pretend nothing is happening. They become strong so you cannot mistake that they are there.

You may feel like a dirty dog. What was way down inside when you were struggling to begin prayer is now way up inside. It is so strong.

You begin to think, "I could make a lot more money on my job if I were working overtime. The kids wanted to go fishing, but what did I do? I went down to the prayer closet."

These things build until you start getting angry over it. Then you get caught in the trap. When you report to prayer, you get depressed because prayer shines more light on your problem.

So you back out and say, "Praying in tongues was not what it was cracked up to be. It did not edify me. I started feeling worse."

The reason He lets these things loose is because, whether you believe it or not, you are at the highest point of edification and able to deal with them. You are at the impasse.

This is not the time to stop. This is the time to press. Recognize those things for what they are. Keep your mouth shut. Double up on your prayer if necessary.

When you get past the impasse, the war that kept you out of the closet will be replaced by peace. You will have joy entering into the closet.

I have more news for you: you are heading toward a bigger impasse, and maybe another one. But you will eventually become a first-class intercessor, and on the other side of it will be revival, because there will not be a thing this side of hell the devil can do about you.

That is called edification: building yourself up on your most holy faith, above a sense-dominated walk, keeping yourself in the love of God.

The Good Fight Is Returning to the Closet Until the Flesh Loses Its Rule

Romans 8:13-14 says:

For if ye live after the flesh, ye shall die: but if ye through the Spirit do mortify the deeds of the body, ye shall live.

For as many as are led by the Spirit of God, they are the sons of God.

It is through the Spirit that you deal with the flesh. As many as will accept the leadership of the Spirit are the sons of God. He is automatically leading you out of a walk dominated by the flesh and into a glorious walk of sonship and maturity, where the flesh does not put a ceiling over your life, but you put a ceiling over it.

The flesh does not rule you; you rule it.

It is through the Spirit that you mortify. As many as are led by the Spirit of God are the sons of God.

You cannot get down for an hour and pray without building yourself toward and eventually past something that has kept you walking the same way now as you did a year ago, three years ago, or five years ago.

You cannot give yourself to two hours of prayer a day without building yourself toward and eventually past that ugly ceiling that kept you like you were for ten years.

My friend, you have declared war. It is called the walk of the Spirit.

"I thought finances were my problem."

No.

"Then it is the devil."

What is it?

You.

"I thought I was supposed to fight the devil."

You are supposed to fight yourself back into the prayer closet. You are dealing with him, but the fight is to stay where the Holy Spirit can work.

"I thought I was supposed to fight the mountain."

If you said, "Mountain, be removed," and really wanted the problem out of your life, you had better put your swimming trunks on, because you are the mountain, and you are going to find yourself swimming back.

What is the good fight of faith? It is whether I can believe what Jesus said about it.

If I cannot believe it, the fight is not over whether He did it. The fight is whether I will do the things the Holy Spirit needs from me to reveal Jesus. The fight is to go back into the closet and stay there until I have won.

His commission is to guide me into all truth, and His Word is truth.

He that speaks in an unknown tongue speaks not to men but to God. No man understands him because it is not to be interpreted for edification. He is speaking mysteries and divine secrets.

If I prophesy, I exhort, comfort, and edify the church because the mind of God is manifested. But when I speak with tongues, I edify, exhort, and comfort myself because His mind is being manifested in me as an individual.

That starts building me toward my impasse. When I am strong enough, God reveals these things, and I purge them, mortify them, and put them to death.

When I make it to the other side of the impasse, I am unmanageable by the devil.